Praise in Homage to the Stūpas of the Eight Great Places

Aṣṭamahāsthānacaityavandanāstava · Toh 1168 · Derge Tengyur

གནས་ཆེན་པོ་བརྒྱད་ཀྱི་མཆོད་རྟེན་ལ་ཕྱག་འཚལ་བའི་བསྟོད་པ

Praise in Homage to the Stūpas of the Eight Great Places, known in Sanskrit as Aṣṭamahāsthānacaityavandanāstava and in Tibetan as Né Chenpo Gyé kyi Chöten la Chaktsalwé Töpa, is a short devotional hymn in verse which, according to its colophon, was composed by Śrī Harṣadeva, king of Kashmir, for the sake of his mother. It pays homage to the stūpas marking the great events of the Buddha's life, among them his birth, his awakening, the turning of the wheel of Dharma, the great miracle, the descent from the realm of the gods and his passing beyond sorrow, and then extends that homage to stūpas and relic shrines at sacred sites across India and in lands such as Kashmir, China, Sri Lanka, Nepal and Kāmarūpa. Its later verses reach further still, to the stūpas on Mount Kailāsa and the summit of Mount Meru and in the abodes of nāgas, gods and knowledge-holders, and it closes with a vow to bow each day to every stūpa and every image of the Buddha, beneath the earth, upon it and in the heavens. It is Toh 1168 in the Tengyur, where it is placed among the hymns of praise (stotra) that make up the Praises section.

In Sanskrit: a aṣṭa mahā sthāna caita banṅa nāma stavaḥ
In Tibetan: Praise in Homage to the Stūpas of the Eight Great Places.

Homage to the youthful Mañjuśrī.

Birth, unequalled awakening, the turning of the virtuous wheel of Dharma,
The stūpa first honored by the three worlds, the great miracle,
This place of the descent from the gods, gleaming like the color of the snow mountains,
And the place where the Sugata (the Buddha) passed beyond sorrow: to these I bow my head.

Vaiśālī, Vārāṇasī, the Mountain of the Child-Killer, the bank where the Fierce One was bound,
Śrāvastī, the foot of the tree of awakening, Kuśinagara the excellent town, Kapilavastu, Lumbinī,
Kauśāmbī, Dense Treasury, the excellent Town of Equality, the land of the Heroic Protector,

And whatever other stūpas there are of the One with the Ten Powers (the Buddha): to them too I bow my head.

Kashmir and the land of China, the Snows, and the one called Yamunā,
Siṃhala (Sri Lanka) and Oṭe, Sindhu, Shingphal, Bagamangwa, Khakola,
Nepal, Kāmarūpa, the supreme Expanse of the Vase, and the excellent land of Kāñcī,
And whatever other reliquaries there are of the One with the Ten Powers: to them too I bow my head.

Kailāsa, the snow mountain that stands in the Himālaya, Mount Mandara, and the summit of Mount Meru,
The abodes of the nāgas, Vijaya, the abodes of the yakṣas, and the abodes of the knowledge-holders and perfected ones (vidyādharas and siddhas),
The abodes of Brahmā and Viṣṇu, and the abodes of Paśupati (Śiva), the sun and the moon,
And whatever other stūpas there are of the One with the Ten Powers: to them too I bow my head.

The eight stūpas sprung from the One with the Ten Powers, holding his relics, with jewels at their heart; the one made from the urn,
And likewise the one of the embers; the jeweled stūpas, exquisitely beautiful like snow and silver;
All the stūpas, however many, without exception, that stand beneath the earth, upon the earth, and on the summits of the god realms,
And wherever images of the Buddha abide: to these I shall bow my head each and every day.

This concludes the Praise in Homage to the Stūpas of the Eight Great Places, composed by the king of Kashmir, Śrī Harṣadeva, for the sake of his mother.

It was translated by the Indian preceptor Rājaśrījñānamitra and the translator Kheu Gé Yönten Pal.

Translator's Notes

- In the first verse, the line about the stūpa first honored by the three worlds does not plainly name one of the eight places and is translated as it stands. Several places in the second and third verses could not be identified with confidence: the Mountain of the Child-Killer, the bank where the Fierce One was bound, Dense Treasury, the Town of Equality (perhaps Sāṃkāśya, whose name suggests "likeness"), the land of the Heroic Protector, the Snows, and the Expanse of the Vase are translated by their meaning, while Oṭe, Shingphal, Bagamangwa and Khakola are given as the Tibetan spells them. Vijaya in the fourth verse is likewise unidentified; it may be Indra's palace Vaijayanta. In the second verse the Tibetan reads srong where grong, "town," is evidently meant, giving Kuśinagara. The urn and the embers in the last verse are the stūpas built over the vessel used to divide the Buddha's relics and over the embers of his pyre. The author's name, spelled Hariśadeva in the Tibetan, is taken as Harṣadeva.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.